



LOS ANGELES Fire Chief Kristin Crowley, left, and Mayor Karen Bass, shown at a Jan. 11 news conference, increasingly clashed over the response to the Palisades fire, which culminated Friday in Crowley’s firing.

District attorney opposes a new trial for Menendez brothers in ’89 killings

Hochman says he’ll respond to resentencing request in ‘coming weeks’

BY SALVADOR HERNANDEZ, RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

Los Angeles County Dist. Atty. Nathan Hochman announced Friday that he’s opposing a petition by attorneys for Erik and Lyle Menendez asking the court to take another look at their case amid new sexual assault allegations they say corroborate a history of abuse.

But Hochman stopped short of shutting down the possibility of resentencing the brothers, who are serving life terms for killing their



California Department of Corrections

ERIK MENENDEZ, left, and his brother, Lyle, were given life terms for the 1989 murders of their parents in Beverly Hills. A hearing to determine whether the brothers should be resentenced is set for March 20.

parents, saying he’ll revisit the issue in “the coming weeks.”

The 1989 killings of Jose and Kitty Menendez inside the family’s Beverly Hills home, and the highly publicized trials that followed, sparked documentaries, films and a recent television series that have renewed public interest in the case decades later. Revelations made in the last year have also prompted new consideration of their crimes and pleas for the brothers to be freed.

A habeas corpus petition filed on behalf of the brothers in Los Angeles [See **Menendez**, A8]

Bass dismisses L.A. fire chief, faulting response in Palisades

Firefighters union says mayor is making Crowley ‘a scapegoat’ over the crisis.

BY DAKOTA SMITH, JULIA WICK, DAVID ZAHNISER AND TONY BARBOZA

Los Angeles Mayor Karen Bass ousted Fire Chief Kristin Crowley over her handling of the Palisades fire Friday, adding to the turmoil that has enveloped City Hall.

Bass took that step after publicly ramping up criticism of Crowley in recent days, complaining that she had not heard from the chief until after the fire broke out, while also questioning the chief’s deployment decisions.

engines that could have been on patrol along the hill-sides and canyons and potentially put out the fire when it was still small.

Crowley did not immediately respond to a request for comment about her dismissal. LAFD spokesperson Erik Scott said the department was “aware of the mayor’s announcement” and had “no further comments or interviews on this matter at this time.”

LAFD veteran Ronnie Villanueva will serve as interim chief. He retired seven months ago as chief deputy of emergency operations after 41 years with the department, according to the mayor’s office.

Crowley’s dismissal drew immediate backlash from the firefighters union, whose leaders supported her last month when she spoke out about needing more city resources.

“Crowley is being made a scapegoat, and she’s being terminated for telling the truth,” said Freddy Escobar, president of United Firefighters of Los Angeles City Local 112.

Escobar disputed Bass’ rationale for firing Crowley, saying that an outside investigation into the fire is already underway. He also asserted that the department lacks a sufficient number of trucks and engines for the 1,000 firefighters who were sent home hours before the fire started.

But several former LAFD chief officers told The Times that keeping the firefighters on duty would have enabled the department to send dozens of extra engines to the Palisades and other high-risk areas. And firefighters not assigned to the additional engines would have been available for other tasks.

Councilmember Monica Rodriguez, whose northeast San Fernando Valley district has experienced major hill-



ROBERTO SCHMIDT AP

PBS on edge over funding

Political pressure isn’t new to the outlet, but now Trump’s FCC is focusing on sponsorships. **BUSINESS, A7**

Chinese students like U.S. schools

Families may debate whether to send kids, but many still believe degree leads to better life. **PERSPECTIVES, A2**

Altadena’s past comes into view

After the Eaton fire, residents imagine what rebuilding could look like for the city’s future. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny and very warm. L.A. Basin: 80/54. **B8**

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Scientists warn about water safety in fire-stricken areas of L.A.

Carcinogen benzene poses risks even without ingestion.

BY NOAH HAGGERTY

Public utilities in both the Eaton and Palisades fire burn scars have reported detecting the carcinogen ben-

zene in parts of their water systems.

State regulators have recommended the utilities issue “do not drink” and “do not boil” notices, which still permit residents to use the water for showers, hand-washing, laundry and other daily activities.

The state said the order attempts to balance safety

with the need for water, but some scientists warned that using the water, even for purposes other than drinking or cooking, could pose a risk.

Studies have linked long-term exposure to benzene through inhalation or ingestion to the development of blood cancers such as leukemia. Research has also found long-term exposure

can result in anemia, which can leave patients feeling weak and tired; a low white blood cell count, which debilitates the immune system; and a low platelet count, which leads to excessive bleeding and bruising.

So far, two of Altadena’s three customer-owned water utilities have detected the carcinogen.

Lincoln Avenue Water Co. said that it had taken over 350 samples, and that of the 296 samples it had analyzed — with results posted on the California State Water Resources Control Board’s website — 30 had contamination above the state’s maximum allowed level, with concentrations as

COLUMN ONE

Out of the embers, they found solace in the timbres



“WE LOST our house,” Palisades Symphony Orchestra violinist Helen Bendix, center, wrote in a brief email. Fifteen other musicians did as well.

Palisades Symphony dedicates concert to those who lost homes

BY THOMAS CURWEN

When Denisa Hanna opened the text and saw images of the flames and smoke of the Palisades fire advancing from the highlands, she knew she had to cancel rehearsal.

She was safe in her home, Mid-City, but the pictures had come from the secretary of Palisades Lutheran Church, who was evacuating. The roads were jammed and the wind was howling.

“Please stay safe and say prayers for our friends near this horrible disaster,” Hanna, the president of the Palisades Symphony Orchestra, wrote in an email to its members.

They had planned to gather that night at the church on Sunset Boulevard, their first practice of the new year. For almost 60 years, the all-volunteer orchestra — together with the Brentwood Palisades Chorale — had served the community with a series of annual programs, and their first concert of 2025 was just



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